



A COZY ROGUELITE POINT-&-CLICK ADVENTURE

Festival of Souls

What does it mean to belong — and does connection span lifetimes?

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT · VERTICAL SLICE

in the spirit of Outer Wilds · Spiritfarer · Frieren

Concept

A cozy roguelite **point-and-click** adventure set in a hand-painted magical world in the spirit of *Outer Wilds*, *Spiritfarer*, and *Frieren*, where you **explore, collect, and discover**.

THE ONE QUESTION

The game explores one question: what does it mean to belong, and does connection span lifetimes?

You are a mage in a warm, hand-painted world who has arrived in a new town in the days before the Festival of Souls. You forage, craft, learn folk magic, and get to know your neighbors — and by discovering spells and items and learning about people, you shape how Festival night turns out.

The Hook. *The Lantern Arch lights the way for souls to return, one night a year, so their loved ones can remember them.* That is what the whole town spends the week building toward — and why the festival matters to everyone in it.

One life unfolds across many festivals: the town grows familiar, your home fills, your bonds deepen year over year. Begin a **new life** and the souls return in shuffled roles — the blacksmith may now be the postman, a friend now a brother — while each soul's essence and personality stays fixed. The bonds you built carry across lifetimes.

Inspirations

- **Outer Wilds** — knowledge is the key; a notebook tracks the items, spells, and relationships you uncover. Knowledge travels free and never expires, and the timed run becomes a move budget.
- **Spiritfarer** — cozy, social-forward rhythm: talk, gift, and tend, with the day soft-limited by the world (light fades, shops close) — never an energy bar.
- **Frieren** — tone and voice: restraint, dialogue patterns, and collectible folk magic.





1.1 · A TRULY COZY ROGUELITE

Cozy in the mechanics, not the paint

Most "cozy roguelites" are cozy paint on a tension engine — they keep combat, permadeath, or push-your-luck and just make it *look* cozy. We invert each pillar instead: keep its *structure*, re-tune it to produce warmth where it would normally produce tension.

ROGUELITE PILLAR	ITS USUAL TENSION	OUR COZY INVERSION
Run / permadeath	Death ends the run; you lose progress	<i>Cannot be lost, only lived.</i> A life ends in a festival, or in a chosen new life — the harshest mechanic becomes a warm, elective reincarnation.
Procedural variation	Unfamiliar layout; threat assessment	The reshuffle re-deals <i>roles</i> (essence fixed); each screen re-draws its foraging. Novelty is reunion and rediscovery — never danger.
Meta-progression	Unlock power to survive harder fights	Your own knowledge is the meta-progression — nothing mechanical unlocks; you carry forward <i>knowing more</i> . Collection and bonds accrue alongside it.
Escalating challenge	Enemies ramp up; the run tests you	Escalating <i>intimacy</i> — bonds deepen, dialogue warms, the festival grows grander with depth.
Build discovery	Assemble a synergy build under pressure	Discover spells and folk magic; discovery is the reward, without the optimization stress.

The engine: a limited timeline and competing goals. The one pillar we replace outright is push-your-luck risk. Here the pressure is **time, not loss**: there is only so much time before the festival and more worth doing than the days allow — deepen a bond, forage a spell, help a soul's arc, gather for the festival. You choose which to advance each day. Decisions that matter and never sting.



Design Pillars

Discovery is the reward

Never hand the player the answer. Watching a neighbor cast gives clues, not the spell; the player still confirms by trying.

Cozy rhythm

Never hard-stop the player. No single-chain dead-ends, no forced sequence. A stuck player always has another live thing to do.

Pull, not push

Never issue a directed command or quest-arrow. The world *offers* leads; it never orders.

Knowledge in the player's head

Never flag-block a gate the player can solve. Gates are *performed* — cast the spell, know where the item is — never a "visited X?" boolean.

Non-violent core

Never resolve a beat with a fight, a fail-punish, or a threat. Conflict is social and internal, never combat.

Strategy over dexterity

Never gate anything on timing, aim, reflex, or precision. Every gate is knowledge, recall, or a social state.

Agentic AI accelerates, it never decides

Never ship a line no human approved. Agents generate volume and check consistency; a human reviews and approves every line before it ships.



Core Loop

Collect

Pick up anything collectible: components, made things, mementos, spell-phrases (knowledge), and sounds. Listening is Collect applied to sound.

Make

Combine components plus learned knowledge into an output — a spell, a dish, a craft, a piece of art. One structure for all three.

Use

Apply a held thing to a target: ignite a lantern, still the water, scratch a cat. Presenting an item or sound to a neighbor is a Use — their reaction is the result.

Converse

Talk to an NPC. Distinct from Use: no object changes hands — the exchange is dialogue.

Starting a life

On a new game — no save data yet — you start with the mage archetype, in the town or the forest. A day runs **morning** → **afternoon** → **evening** on a move budget. Each screen hosts solo interactions and social interactions with any souls present. The first screen teaches the four verbs by doing.

The satchel, the notebook, the home

You carry a satchel and a notebook; the notebook holds the knowledge you've collected and can be opened anytime. At day's end you keep only what fits the satchel and return home — or end early to bank a full pack plus what your arms carry (pack-triage). Your home is this life's hub: decorate it, carry items back out. It starts empty each life; everything you've ever collected is recorded permanently in the meta-hub. When ready, open the calendar and pick the next day's location.

The festival cycle

A cycle is the lead-up to one festival night — one week in the slice, up to three in the full game. The lead-up builds toward the night; the outcome depends on your choices. On a new cycle in the same life, the calendar turns toward next year's festival — time passes, neighbors remember what you did, and you learn the past year through dialogue. Roles stay fixed; home, bonds, and collection carry from one festival to the next.



§3 · CORE LOOP (CONT.)

Ending a festival

Each festival night closes on an ending vignette shaped by your decisions, then time advances. Every NPC carries a goal for the festival you can help with; the **grandness** of the festival depends on how many goals are completed.

A new life

Once a save exists, a new save slot lets you pick your role — for the slice, mage or blacksmith — locked for as long as that life runs. A new life reshuffles the souls: personalities fixed, roles re-dealt (the baker may return a herbalist). **Bond level persists across lives**, leading to different outcomes, and as it deepens the dialogue **warms** — more familiar, more shorthand. Your care shows up in the world, too: a neighbor you once helped find her voice now speaks up for a stranger.

3.1 · FESTIVAL OUTCOME

A spectrum, not a branch

Festival night reads the cycle — the **bonds** you deepened and the **contributions** you made — through one success function, rendered as a **spectrum**. There are no separate festival scenes: it is one festival, dressed differently in its light, its vignette, and who shows up.

 Quiet A modest festival; a few souls present, low warm light.	 Warm The town turns out; the square fills, the lanterns are lit.	 Grand The fullest turnout, the Lantern Arch at its brightest.	 Souls of the World Rare top, at exceptional depth: the festival briefly shows the souls of the world.
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Soul-want × role-goal. Every occupation carries a civic festival goal — the blacksmith forges the Arch centerpiece, the baker prepares the feast, the postman delivers the letters — and how far the town gets is what dresses the festival. Each soul has a fixed **want** (essence); each life deals it a **role** carrying a goal. The pairing lands somewhere on **tension ↔ alignment** — and that permutation is what makes the same soul's story different from one life to the next.

Two tracks, never colliding.** The festival goal is external and moves the tier; a soul's inner arc is internal and moves nothing. Neither is the "correct" way to play — which keeps the spectrum from collapsing into a score. There is no hard-lose and no game-over: the ending vignette is guaranteed. Success is depth of connection reached, never a score shown. **The game cannot be lost, only lived.



3.2 · ONBOARDING

The first screen teaches by doing

On a new save you pick a persona and open in the world with a few **safe, obvious hints** that teach the four verbs one at a time: something to **Collect** in reach, something to **Make** from it, something to **Use** it on, and a neighbor to **Converse** with. The **notebook** is a **found object** — you pick it up, and it's already yours. By the end of the first screen the player has done all four verbs.

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PART II · GAME MECHANICS

Magic System

Learned by exploring or conversing, confirmed by doing. Seeing a neighbor cast on a target gives a clue, not the spell; you confirm by trying it yourself.

- A **spell is a phrase plus components**. The notebook's spellbook records what you've learned; you learn a spell by casting it successfully once.
- To cast, select components from your inventory and input the phrase.
- **Physical outcomes only**. Spells produce physical effects, never a mood or a dictated behavior; the outcome is receiver-determined, and "no effect" is an honest result.
- **Cost & quality**. Anyone can cast. **Mage is the one high-mana role**, casting bigger and cleaner; every other role casts at one shared baseline. Mana shapes a cast's *quality*, never whether you can cast.
- **Magic unlocks screens**. Casting is a knowledge-key — watch a neighbor burn a dry hedge, then do it to open the way. Traversal is gated by what you know, not a flag.

```
// starter set - slice count: 10 spells
spell "ignite" { components: [sticks] }
spell "scratch" { components: [wool] }
spell "breath" { components: [grass, dirt] }
// cast = phrase + components → receiver-determined outcome
```





4.1 · RECEIVER-DETERMINED OUTCOMES

The verb says what was done, never what happened

The target of any directed interaction determines the outcome. Ignite-on-sticks catches; ignite-on-a-person does nothing. Spells produce physical outcomes only — never a mood, never a dictated behavior; "no effect" is an honest result.

Worked run: **ignite**

Run for real through the narrative crew against seven receivers, to prove receiver-determined outcomes end-to-end through the agent pipeline.

RECEIVER	OUTCOME	REACTION
Stick	Catches	Catches at the tip and holds a small, steady flame.
Hedge	Catches, clears the path	Burns through its dry inner branches, opening the way it had blocked.
Furnace	State-dependent	Unlit & stocked: it lights, draft picking up. Already lit: nothing changes.
Bread	Scorches, no catch	Crust blackens and curls; the loaf is ruined. <i>If Toby's present:</i> "What did you do that for?"
Cat	No physical effect	Light washes over its fur and fades; it bolts under the fence, then grooms from a distance.
Toby <i>(direct)</i>	No physical effect	"Save that for the oven."
Ilsa <i>(direct)</i>	No physical effect	<i>(null — no reaction)</i>



Collectibles

CATEGORY	ROLE	PERSISTENCE	EXAMPLES
Components	Foraged ingredients, consumable; feed Magic & Make	pack-triaged	a berry · a river stone
Made things	Outputs of Make; some consumable, some giftable	pack-triaged	a warm loaf · a carving
Mementos	Hub decoration & achievement markers	pack-triaged	a ribbon · a pressed flower
Gifts	Key items given to NPCs to advance story	drawn from above	a given keepsake
Sounds <i>(audio)</i>	Travel free, no pack space; show / gift / component	free, like knowledge	a festival bell · a tune
Tools	Non-consumable Use-family items	pack-triaged	a lantern · a small knife

Scope: roughly 3 per category, about 15 distinct items (gifts overlap mementos and made-things); final counts from the content budget.

Availability is randomized per screen. Each location draws from its own pool, so no two visits offer the same spread — the forest may hold river stones today, feathers tomorrow. This feeds the limited-timeline engine: you adapt the day's goals to what's out. **Guardrail:** items a gate or a soul's arc depends on are exempt — always obtainable. Components come from pools with more than one source, so a missing one means foraging elsewhere or coming back, never a dead-end.



World & Progression

6.1 · Save-state — what the save file records

Save-state tracks two boundaries: **within a life** (festival to festival, as the calendar turns) and **across a new life** (a fresh slot, which reshuffles). Delete one slot to wipe just that life — the meta-hub and other slots are untouched; a hard disk wipe erases everything, meta-hub included. **Three save slots** — three parallel lives on separate timelines; the meta-hub collection is shared, while each life's home starts empty.

DATA	WITHIN A LIFE	ACROSS A NEW LIFE
Spells	Yes — notebook	Yes — notebook
Sounds (audio)	Yes	Yes
Physical items	Kept in your home across festivals	No — new home starts empty
Bond level	Yes, grows	Yes, carries across lives
Roles / relationships	Fixed	Re-dealt
In-game home	Accrues across festivals	No — starts empty
Meta-hub collection	Grows as you discover	Yes — permanent, shared; display-only

6.2 · THE GAME CLOCK

Day

Morning → **afternoon** → **evening**. Open in the morning with a move budget (~3–5 screen-moves); afternoon lets you move to a new location or stay for a few more moves (~3); the day ends in the evening wherever you are — when evening-only spots like the Tavern open — then home to pick tomorrow's location.

Festival cycle

The lead-up to a festival night — one week in the slice (currently 5 days, expandable), up to three weeks in the full game — then the night and its ending vignette.

The turn of the year

After each festival the calendar advances toward next year's; time passes, neighbors remember, and the next cycle begins in the same life. Continuing past one turn is a full-game target — grayed out for the slice.

A life (a save slot)

Many cycles, continuous: **cycle** → **festival** → **turn of the year** → **cycle**... Roles are chosen once, at creation, and stay fixed; home, bonds, and collection accrue.

A new life (a new timeline)

A fresh slot re-deals roles (essence & personality fixed); bonds carry across.



Cast (Souls)

7.1 · The role pool

ROLE	FESTIVAL GOAL
Mage (<i>the newcomer</i>)	<i>Personal, not civic:</i> collect magic from around the world
Blacksmith	Forges the new Lantern Arch centerpiece
Baker	Prepares the communal feast
Postman	Delivers the festival letters
Herbalist	Brews the tonic that wards off the first frost
Priest	Leads the rite that lights the Arch and calls the souls home
Farmer	Brings in the harvest that feeds the festival week

Mage is not player-exclusive. Whoever holds it is "the newcomer." On a new save you pick from the full pool before the engine deals the rest; the pick locks for the life. Keep mage and you stay the newcomer; pick otherwise and a soul becomes it. The slice offers mage & blacksmith only.

7.2 · DEEP SOULS (3)

Three theories of belonging

SOUL	ESSENCE — WANT + BEHAVIOR	CONVICTION	ARC
The Keeper <i>Mara</i>	Belonging is tended — keep the festival, and the connection it anchors, from slipping into the past. Keeps a drawer of unclaimed objects and a corner "set for two."	Won't leave or let the tradition lapse — leaving means admitting the loss is final.	Clutch → transform: the bond re-forms; loss isn't permanent.
The Giver <i>Toby (m)</i>	Belonging is earned by being needed — supplies what people are short of before being asked; turns any gift into a debt he repays.	Won't accept care he hasn't paid for.	Can't receive → can: being <i>claimed</i> unearned frees him; the player's "I see you" is the corrective.
The Kinbound <i>Ilisa (f)</i>	Belonging is given — blood, family above all; sets places before anyone answers and quietly covers a gap.	Family above all — slow to accept that loyalty runs both ways.	Blood is given → blood is tended: stays blood-first, never arrives at chosen-family.





7.3 · TEXTURE SOULS (5)

The village argues "what is belonging?"

Social-only, one salient signal each — they counter-voice the deep trio from different angles.

SOUL	BELONGING-STANCE	SALIENT SIGNAL
Nell — Content Server (<i>m</i>)	Needed, and at peace with it (counter to the Giver)	Hums while working; never keeps score.
Juno — Found-Family Keeper (<i>f</i>)	Belonging is who you <i>choose</i> (the game's thesis)	Her "family" is unrelated people who all found each other.
Linnet — Half of a Pair (<i>f</i>)	The one bond, out of reach — split by timing	Keeps a small habit for someone now married to another.
Pip — Wonder-Seeker (<i>m</i>)	Belonging is shared wonder, out there to find	Drags people to see small marvels; always mid-discovery.
Bex — Rule-Breaker (<i>m</i>)	Says "you belong" plainly — the authored exception	Names the feeling out loud where everyone deflects.

Name & gender are fixed; role & age are re-dealt — a soul returns recognizable, and the reshuffle changes only their position. The cast is **4 men, 4 women**: Nell (the Giver's counter-voice) is male on purpose, so the contrast reads as *earning vs. ease*, never gender.

7.4 · AGE IS A ROLE FIELD

Each soul carries an **age_band** re-dealt every life exactly like the job — nothing on the essence side may depend on it. Age drives address terms and deference (who is called "boy," who mentors), and makes the reshuffle bite in a channel roles alone don't reach. **All three bands can hold every role**, or the reshuffle breaks.

AGE_BAND	ROUGH YEARS	READS AS
young	late teens – late 20s	Addressed as "boy"/"girl" by elders; still proving themselves
middle	30s – 50s	The default; peer to most of the town
older	60s+	Deferred to; addresses the young familiarly

Life-one assignment. young — Toby, Pip · middle — Mara, Nell, Linnet, Bex · older — Ilsa, Juno.



Levels

8.1 · Town

The festival's home — one scene plus the Square.

- **Square** (*start*) — under the Lantern Arch, which ages across the years; where you arrive.
- **Town scene** — the lived-in heart: market stalls, the commons and well, and the main NPCs at their work (a blacksmith's bench, a baker's counter). Homes open at a certain bond level; the Tavern corner opens in the evening.

8.2 · Forest

One screen plus two knowledge-gated unlocks.

- **Forager's Clearing** (*start*) — onboarding the first time; a normal screen thereafter.
- **Unlock 1** — a path cleared by a spell (e.g. ignite a dry hedge).
- **Unlock 2** — a secret path learned from an NPC.

8.3 · Festival Grounds

The final screen — where the week's work is dressed into festival night.

8.4 · Home Hub

Two spaces sharing one asset set.

- **In-game home** — return at day's end, bank what fits the satchel, and decorate it; it resets empty at the start of each new life.
- **Meta-hub** (*main menu*) — the role-select screen doubles as your permanent collection: every item held and sound heard, tracked across all lives, with new finds unlocked as display-only pieces you arrange.

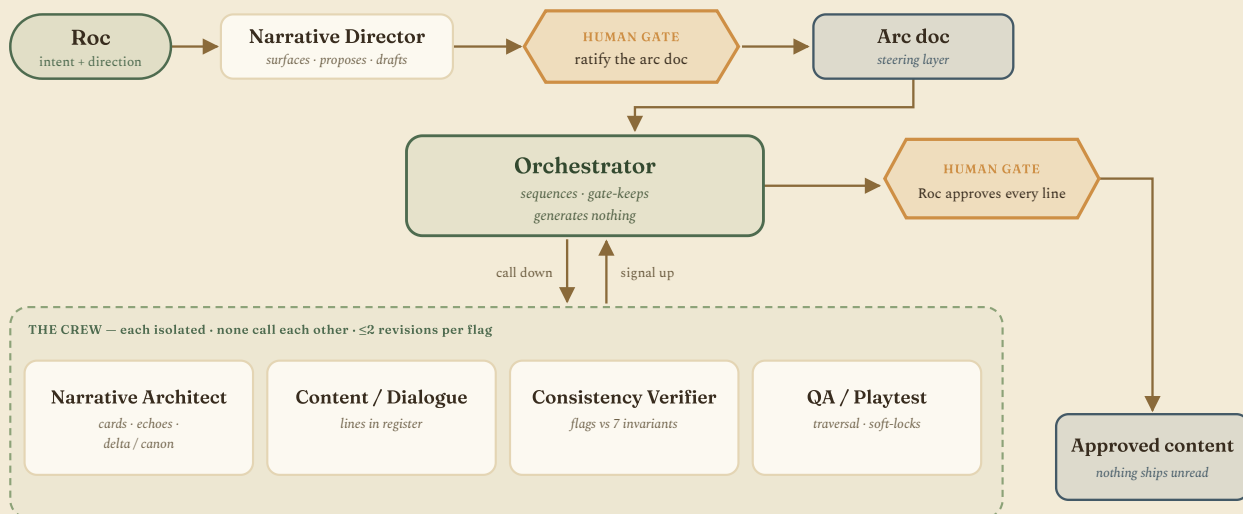


AI Agents & Pipeline

AGENT	OUTPUT / RESPONSIBILITY	BUDGET
Orchestrator	Sequences the crew; hands each worker its input, collects typed output, surfaces human gates, resolves conflicts.	200K
Narrative Director	Steering — surfaces lore, proposes arc-doc fields + tables, drafts the arc doc for ratification. Sets <i>direction</i> .	—
Narrative Architect	Structure — persona cards, the seed→payoff echo map, the NPC codex of locked facts. Writes no player lines.	300K
Content / Dialogue	All player-facing text — NPC lines, lore, descriptions.	700K
Consistency Verifier	Flags each batch against the 8 invariants + voice register. Flags only, never rewrites.	300K
QA / Playtest	Verifies the slice is traversable — no soft-locks, dead-ends, or unreachable wins. Flags only.	250K
Style / Art-Direction	Checks each art variant against the color grammar + silhouette rules; flags drift.	100K
Production / PM	Backlog, review-queue depth, readiness summary. Surfaces risk; makes no design calls.	50K

Budget. One chat's context is ~1M tokens. We assume a **3M total**: the crew shares **2M**, with **1M reserved** for the technical track (programming, Unreal MCP integration).

THE PIPELINE — CALL DOWN, SIGNAL UP



9.2 · MEASURED COST

Cost scales by how often a soul speaks

On 2026-07-25 the crew was **run, not modelled**: a 5-arm model benchmark plus a full stage-2 generation of one soul, 27 agents across two phases. Cost does not scale by soul — it scales by **soul-appearances**.

UNIT	MEASURED	SCALES WITH
Architect — one persona card + echoes	~51K	Souls (paid once each)
Content + Verifier — one soul in one scene	~107K	Soul-appearances

```
// crew budget = 2M tokens
cards      8 souls × 51K   = 411K
remaining  2M - 411K      = 1.59M
appearances 1.59M ÷ 107K   = ~15
```

The slice runs five days × three time-blocks = **15 scene-slots** — so the 2M crew budget affords roughly **one soul-appearance per time-block across the festival week, with zero revisions**. That is the real scope constraint on the roster and on how populated a scene can feel.

9.3 · OPERATING RULES

- **Call down, signal up.** The Orchestrator hands each worker its input and collects a typed output; workers never call each other, so each stays testable in isolation.
- **The human gate lives at the output.** A human reviews and approves — nothing ships unread, and a broken output is never silently swallowed.
- **Bounded work only** — structured output, classification, string-pattern work. Scope the model to the task: stronger reasoning for orchestration, lower tiers for individual tasks.
- **Two revisions per item, then a human looks** — and the count does not reset at a human gate.
- **Every revision brief restates the full constraint set**, never only the defect; a brief that names one problem is an instruction to trade something else for it.



Technical Overview

10.1 · Engine & prototype

Full slice: Ink Script into Unreal (UE5), the Point-and-Click toolkit (Fab), Wwise audio, 3D static-camera scenes. **Fast prototype:** ink + HTML — the quickest way to prove the pipeline in a browser. Ink is *not* throwaway: the content graph built in prototype is the same graph the slice ships on.

10.2 · Two build tracks (so review never blocks assets)

- **Track A — narrative pipeline proof (ink/html).** Proves the seed-to-payoff loop and the content pipeline. Gated by line review.
- **Track B — visual / asset build (Unreal).** Environments, static-camera scenes, audio tags. Runs independently, so review time never stalls visual work.

10.3 · ACCEPTANCE

AREA	MINIMUM	TARGET
Core loop	One week loads and reaches festival night.	Plus the turn of the year + a decision-based ending vignette.
Reshuffle	One hand-scripted role-swap plays on camera.	A second hand-authored reshuffle instance.
Save-state	Bond + collection persist across one new life.	3 slots; meta-hub shared; home resets empty.
Deep-soul arc	1 arc hand-authored, reads distinct, seed→payoff lands.	Agent lines pass the side-by-side distinctness read.
Festival	One festival scene renders at day's-end.	3 tiers + the rare souls-of-the-world display.
Reciprocity	Bond persists across lives.	Dialogue visibly warms over repeated lives.

10.4 · DEFINITION OF DONE

Play a week through

The full core loop, start to festival night.

The game reshuffles

A new life re-deals the souls' roles.

Saves & restores state

Bond levels and collection persist across a new life.

One soul's story is complete

The single deep-soul arc plays end-to-end, seed to payoff.



Scope & Risks

11.1 · MUST / SHOULD / STRETCH

TIER	NARRATIVE	WORLD / LEVELS	AI-PIPELINE
MUST	1 deep soul's arc end-to-end; one seed→payoff echo lands	Forest (1 + 2 unlocks) + Town (Square + 1 scene) + Festival; one week playable to festival night	Persistence + reshuffle work; Content + Consistency produce & check one soul's lines
SHOULD	3 deep souls' key lines authored & distinct; dialogue warms	3 festival tiers; bond-driven change on a repeat reshuffle	Full crew runs; a second hand- authored reshuffle on camera
STRETCH	All 5 texture souls written; the souls-of-the-world top tier	Extra forest screens; richer effects	Style + Production agents live; ink→UE integration spike

11.3 · TOP RISKS (WITH FALLBACK)

NPC perceptual distinctness

Needs real writing samples against the voice guide. *Fallback*: hand-author the 3 deep souls; agents handle texture only.

Reshuffle / persistence coherence

The on-camera swap must read as the same soul in a new role. *Fallback*: hand-script the single swap; the ink prototype validates it.

Ink-to-Unreal integration

The engine must carry from ink into UE. *Fallback*: ship the ink/html build if UE slips; de-risk with an early spike.

Human-review bottleneck

~half a week of review time. *Fallback*: cut to the MUST column — 1 soul, 1 reshuffle, 1 ending.

11.4 · PLANNED SCOPING CUTS — TOP OF THE LIST GOES FIRST

- The second hand-authored reshuffle instance — ship one on-camera swap.
- The Farm (third location) — already cut; then trim extra screen moves.
- Texture souls beyond what the deep arcs need.
- The upper festival tiers — ship quiet/warm; grand + souls-of-the-world last.
- The role pool — trim toward Mage + Blacksmith.

The game cannot be lost, only lived.

